Tuesday, November 3, 2026

St. Martin de Porres

Religious, Dominican lay brother · Feast, November 3



San Martín de Porres, unknown painter, Church of San Pedro, Lima; photo Miguel Angel Chong, CC BY 3.0[1]

1. Unknown painter, *San Martín de Porres*, oil painting, Church of San Pedro, Lima, Peru; photograph by Miguel Angel Chong, 2010, CC BY 3.0 (cropped).

✠ The Essentials

- **Origin:** Lima, Peru.[2] He was the illegitimate son of a Spanish nobleman and Ana Velásquez, a freed slave of African and possibly indigenous descent.[3] Another account names his father as the Spanish knight John de Porres and his mother as a freed Panamanian slave named Anna.[4]
- **Born:** 1579[5]
- **Died:** November 3, 1639, at the Convent of the Rosary in Lima, at the age of 59. As he lay dying, the viceroy of Peru knelt at his bedside to ask his blessing.[6][7] His body was found incorrupt 25 years after his death.[8]
- **Canonized:** May 6, 1962,[9] by Pope St. John XXIII.[10]
- **Patron:** of interracial justice.[11]

✠ His Life in Brief

At 12 Martin was apprenticed to a barber-surgeon, learning to cut hair and tend the sick.[12] In Peru at that time the law barred des-

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2. Vatican News, "St. Martin de Porres, Dominican," Saint of the Day for November 3 (Vatican City: Dicastery for Communication).
3. Ibid.
4. Matthew Bunson, Margaret Bunson, and Stephen Bunson, *Our Sunday Visitor's Encyclopedia of Saints* (Huntington, IN: Our Sunday Visitor), s.v. "Martin de Porres, St."
5. Vatican News, "St. Martin de Porres."
6. Bunson, *Encyclopedia of Saints*, s.v. "Martin de Porres."
7. Vatican News, "St. Martin de Porres."
8. Ibid.
9. John XXIII, Homily at the Canonization of Blessed Martin de Porres, May 6, 1962, *Acta Apostolicae Sedis* 54 (1962): 306.
10. Bunson, *Encyclopedia of Saints*, s.v. "Martin de Porres."
11. Ibid.
12. Vatican News, "St. Martin de Porres."

cendants of African slaves from becoming professed religious.[13] So he asked the Dominicans of Lima to take him as a lay helper, and for eight years he cut the friars' hair, scrubbed, swept, and cared for the poor.[14] The prior, Juan de Lorenzana, then set the law aside and let him take vows.[15] (Our Sunday Visitor's *Encyclopedia of Saints* dates his entry as a lay brother to 1594.[16])

- Some friars mocked him as a "mulatto dog."[17] When the priory fell into debt he offered himself: "I am only a poor mulatto, sell me."[18]
- At 34 he was put in charge of the infirmary, and he cared for friars, noblemen and slaves alike.[19] Rebuked for carrying a beggar covered in sores to his own bed, he answered, "Compassion, my brother, is preferable to cleanliness."[20]
- He founded an orphanage, ministered to African slaves brought to Lima,[21] and was a friend and helper of St. Rose of Lima.[22]

✠ Famous Excerpt: from Pope John XXIII's homily at his canonization (Office of Readings, November 3)

> *"He loved men because he honestly looked on them as God's children and as his own brothers and sisters. Such was his humility that he loved them*

13. Ibid.
14. Ibid.
15. Ibid.
16. Bunson, *Encyclopedia of Saints*, s.v. "Martin de Porres."
17. Vatican News, "St. Martin de Porres."
18. Ibid.
19. Ibid.
20. Ibid.
21. Bunson, *Encyclopedia of Saints*, s.v. "Martin de Porres."
22. Ibid.

> *even more than himself and considered them to be better and more righteous than he was."*[23]

> *"He excused the faults of others. He forgave the bitterest injuries, convinced that he deserved much severer punishments on account of his own sins. He tried with all his might to redeem the guilty; lovingly he comforted the sick; he provided food, clothing and medicine for the poor; he helped, as best he could, farm laborers and Negroes, as well as mulattoes, who were looked upon at that time as akin to slaves: thus he deserved to be called by the name the people gave him: 'Martin of Charity.'"*[24]

✠ 1. Catechesis

Lesson: the equal dignity of every person. Martin was told by law and by some of his brothers that he was less than they were. The Church teaches the opposite:

- All people share the same nature, origin, redemption and calling, "all therefore enjoy an equal dignity" (CCC 1934).[25]
- "Every form of social or cultural discrimination in fundamental personal rights on the grounds of sex, race, color, social conditions, language, or religion must be curbed and eradicated as incompatible with God's design" (CCC 1935).[26]

Ask students: who is treated as "less" in our school, parish or town, and what would Martin do for them this week?

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23. John XXIII, Homily at the Canonization of St. Martin de Porres (May 6, 1962), *Acta Apostolicae Sedis* 54 (1962): 306–9; English in *The Liturgy of the Hours*, Office of Readings, November 3.
24. Ibid.
25. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), no. 1934.
26. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), no. 1935.

✠ 2. Apologetics

Objection: "Christianity is a white, colonial religion that blessed racism." Answer honestly and then go deeper. It is true that in Martin's Peru the law kept descendants of African slaves out of religious profession, and some friars insulted him.[27][28] Those were the sins of Christians and of their society. But the Church's own teaching stood against them: the human race "forms a unity" because of its common origin (CCC 360),[29] and in Christ "there is neither Jew nor Greek, neither slave nor free" (Gal 3:28; see also Acts 17:26). The Church raised this mixed-race son of a freed slave to the altars, and a pope held him up to the whole world as a model.[30] Martin is evidence that the Gospel judges the culture that receives it, not the other way around.

✠ 3. Theology

- **Charity, the form of the virtues:** "The practice of all the virtues is animated and inspired by charity" (CCC 1827).[31] During an epidemic Martin had been forbidden to move the sick for fear of contagion, yet he was found tending a bleeding Indian in his own room. When the prior rebuked him, he answered: "Forgive me and please instruct me, for I did not know that the precept of obedience took precedence over the precept of charity."[32]

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27. Vatican News, "St. Martin de Porres."
28. Ibid.
29. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), no. 360.
30. John XXIII, Canonization Homily, AAS 54:306.
31. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), no. 1827.
32. Vatican News, "St. Martin de Porres."

- **Love of God and neighbor:** John XXIII presented Martin as proof that we reach holiness "first, by loving God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your mind; and second, by loving your neighbor as yourself" (see Mt 22:37–39).[33]
- **The Eucharist and the Cross:** "He had an exceptional love for the great sacrament of the Eucharist and often spent long hours in prayer before the blessed sacrament."[34]

✠ 4. Devotional Prayer

Collect for St. Martin de Porres (Roman Missal, November 3):[35]
O God, who led Saint Martin de Porres by the path of humility to heavenly glory, grant that we may so follow his radiant example in this life as to merit to be exalted with him in heaven. Through our Lord Jesus Christ, your Son, who lives and reigns with you in the unity of the Holy Spirit, God, for ever and ever. Amen.

Practice: Spend time today before the Blessed Sacrament, as Martin did,[36] and then do one hidden act of service for someone others overlook.

✠ Today's Takeaway

Holiness does not wait for the world to treat us fairly. Martin answered contempt with service, and the people gave him the name "Martin of Charity."[37]

St. Martin de Porres, pray for us.

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33. John XXIII, Canonization Homily for St. Martin de Porres.
34. Ibid.
35. *The Roman Missal*, 3rd typical ed., English trans. (ICEL, 2011), Proper of Saints, November 3, Saint Martin de Porres, Collect.
36. John XXIII, Canonization Homily for St. Martin de Porres.
37. Ibid.